

Early Civilisations — Mesopotamia & Egypt

Nile Valley · Mesopotamian inventions · Social structures · Pharaohs & Ziggurats

Key Vocabulary — ESL Historical Guide

What Makes a Civilisation? — The 7 Features

Mesopotamia — The World's First Civilisation

The Invention of Writing — c.3200 BC

The Sumerians invented cuneiform writing around 3200 BC — the earliest known writing system on Earth. They pressed wedge-shaped marks into clay tablets using a stylus (a reed pen). WHY? Trade records — keeping track of grain, livestock, and payments. Writing was not invented for poetry or stories; it was invented for accountancy. Over time, it evolved to record laws (Hammurabi's Code, ~1754 BC), myths (Epic of Gilgamesh), and royal achievements.

Hammurabi's Code — c.1754 BC

Hammurabi, King of Babylon, created one of the earliest written law codes — 282 laws carved onto an 8-foot stone stele. Famous for the principle of "an eye for an eye" (lex talionis). Significance: laws applied to everyone (not just rulers' whims), punishments were proportional, and it protected some vulnerable groups. However — punishments varied by social class, meaning the law was not fully equal. This makes it an excellent source evaluation question at KS3.

Mesopotamian Innovations — Our Legacy

Ancient Egypt — Gift of the Nile

The Pharaoh — God-King

The pharaoh was considered the son of Ra (the sun god) and the earthly incarnation of Horus. This dual role — political ruler AND religious leader — gave the pharaoh absolute authority. Questioning the pharaoh was both treason and blasphemy.

Pyramids — Engineering Marvels

The Great Pyramid of Giza (built for Pharaoh Khufu, ~2560 BC) contains 2.3 million stone blocks averaging 2.5 tonnes each. It remained the tallest human structure for 3,800 years.

- **WHY pyramids? The pharaoh's soul (ka) needed his body preserved (mummification) and his belongings ready for the afterlife.**
- **The pyramid's geometry pointed to Orion's belt — associated with Osiris, god of the afterlife.**
- **Critical thinking: Who built the pyramids? NOT slaves — recent archaeology shows they were skilled, paid workers who received food, healthcare, and burial honours.**

Hieroglyphics & the Rosetta Stone

Egyptian hieroglyphics (~3100 BC) used over 700 picture symbols. After Egypt fell to Rome, the ability to read hieroglyphics was LOST for 1,400 years. The Rosetta Stone (196 BC, discovered 1799) showed the same text in hieroglyphics, Demotic, and Greek. Jean-Francois Champollion used the Greek to crack the code in 1822 — unlocking 3,000 years of Egyptian history.

Mesopotamia vs Egypt — Key Comparison

Key Dates Timeline

Knowledge Check — Questions & Model Answers

- What does "Mesopotamia" literally mean? → "Land between the rivers" (meso = middle, potamos = river). Modern-day Iraq. Widely considered the cradle of civilisation.
- Which civilisation invented the world's first writing system, and when? → Mesopotamia (Sumerians), c.3200 BC. Cuneiform — initially for trade records. Egyptian hieroglyphics followed around 3100 BC.
- Why was the Rosetta Stone crucial? → It showed the same decree in hieroglyphics, Demotic, and Greek. Champollion used the Greek to decode hieroglyphics in 1822 — unlocking 3,000 years of Egyptian history.
- What is the historical significance of Hammurabi's Code? → One of the world's earliest written law codes establishing that laws should be written, public, and

proportional. However — punishments varied by social class, so it was not truly equal.

- Why was Egypt more politically stable than Mesopotamia? → Egypt's predictable Nile floods provided reliable agriculture and its desert borders provided natural defence. Mesopotamia's unpredictable flooding and open borders led to more frequent invasions and political instability. Geography shapes civilisation.